

CLC

Educational Institute

DIGITAL SAT — READING & WRITING

Standard English Conventions

Theory & Worked Questions — Presentation Companion

- 17 grammar skills, one representative worked question per skill
- Boundaries | Sentence Structure | Form, Structure & Sense | Higher-Level Skills
- Companion to the full 136-question Standard English Conventions Study Companion

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The 17 Skills

1. The Comma
2. The Semicolon
3. The Colon
4. The Dash
5. The Period
6. Independent vs. Dependent Clauses
7. Run-Ons & Comma Splices
8. Fragments
9. Logical Separation of Ideas
10. Parts of Speech
11. Verbs & Tenses
12. Subject-Verb Agreement
13. Pronouns
14. Nouns & Apostrophes
15. Adjectives & Adverbs
16. Modifiers
17. Parallel Structure, Conjunctions & Comparisons

Core Rules

- **Introductory Elements Take One Comma** — A word, phrase, or subordinate clause that comes before the main clause and sets the scene — time, place, condition, or a participial phrase — is followed by a single comma before the subject of the main clause begins.
- **Nonessential Information Is Boxed In on Both Sides** — If a clause, phrase, or appositive can be deleted without changing which specific person or thing the sentence is about, it is nonessential — and nonessential material must be set off with a comma before it and a comma after it, never just one.
- **Essential Information Takes No Commas at All** — If that same kind of clause or phrase is required to identify which specific person or thing is meant, it is essential, and adding commas around it is always wrong — the commas would falsely suggest the information is removable.

Common Trap: A nonessential clause missing just one comma of its required pair — the sentence looks "mostly" right.

The grant proposal _____ ultimately received the highest score of any application that year.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A.** that the research team submitted just before the funding deadline
- B.** , that the research team submitted just before the funding deadline,
- C.** that the research team submitted, just before the funding deadline,
- D.** , that the research team submitted just before the funding deadline

Correct Answer: A. that the research team submitted just before the funding deadline

Explanation

- "That the research team submitted just before the funding deadline" identifies which specific proposal is meant — it is essential to the sentence's meaning.
- An essential clause takes no commas at all, since removing it would leave the reader unsure which proposal is being discussed.
- Boxing this clause in commas would falsely suggest it can be deleted without changing what the sentence identifies.

Rule: A clause that identifies which specific person or thing is meant is essential and takes no surrounding commas.

Tip: Delete the clause and check whether the sentence still identifies the same, specific thing. If it no longer does, the clause is essential and gets no commas.

Trap: Choice B feels safer because it "matches" the nonessential pattern from other questions, but here removing the clause would leave "the grant proposal ultimately received the highest score" — which proposal is left unclear.

Core Rules

- **A Semicolon Joins Two Independent Clauses** — A semicolon can do exactly what a period does — separate two complete sentences — while signaling that the two ideas are closely related enough to stay in one sentence.
- **Semicolon + Conjunctive Adverb, Then a Comma** — Words like however, therefore, moreover, and consequently connect two independent clauses using the pattern: independent clause; conjunctive adverb, independent clause. The semicolon does the real joining work; the comma after the adverb is separate.
- **Semicolons Separate Items in a Complex List** — When a list's individual items already contain their own internal commas, semicolons separate the items themselves so a reader can tell where one item ends and the next begins.

Common Trap: A comma used where the sentence actually needs a semicolon in front of however/therefore/moreover.

The proposal has strong support among junior staff_____ however, several senior board members remain openly unconvinced.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. ;
- B. ,
- C. . However
- D. ; ,

Correct Answer: A. ;

Explanation

- "However" is a conjunctive adverb connecting two independent clauses, and it is already followed by a comma in the given text.
- The pattern is: independent clause; conjunctive adverb, independent clause — the semicolon does the actual joining.
- A comma alone cannot join two independent clauses, even when a transitional word like "however" follows it.

Rule: Before a conjunctive adverb (however, therefore, moreover, consequently) that joins two independent clauses, use a semicolon — the comma after the adverb is a separate, additional mark.

Tip: Treat "however," "therefore," and similar words like independent-clause openers: whatever comes right before one, if both sides are complete sentences, needs a semicolon, not a comma.

Trap: Choice B is the single most common semicolon error on the exam — a comma before "however" when both surrounding clauses are independent.

Core Rules

- Only a Complete Independent Clause Can Precede a Colon — The words before a colon must be able to stand alone as a full sentence. A colon can never follow a fragment, and it can never sit directly after a preposition or between a verb and its own object.
- What Follows a Colon Renames, Lists, or Explains — Think of the colon as functioning like an equals sign — everything after it must restate, itemize, or clarify the idea that was just stated, not introduce an unrelated new idea.
- A Colon Can Introduce a Word, a Phrase, a List, or a Full Clause — Unlike a semicolon, what follows a colon does not need to be an independent clause — a single word or short phrase is equally valid, as long as it completes the idea set up on the left.

Common Trap: A colon placed after "including" or "such as," both of which already function as their own introducers and never take a colon.

Investigators eventually traced the outage to its true source_____ a single corroded cable buried beneath the parking structure.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A.** :
- B.** , which was
- C.** : which was
- D.** being

Correct Answer: A. :

Explanation

- "Investigators eventually traced the outage to its true source" is a complete independent clause.
- "A single corroded cable buried beneath the parking structure" renames exactly what that "true source" was.
- A colon alone, with no additional connecting words, is the cleanest and most precise way to make that connection.

Rule: When the material after the blank simply renames a noun just mentioned, a colon alone — with no extra connecting words — is the most precise choice.

Tip: If a choice pairs a colon or semicolon with an extra connecting phrase like "which was," check whether that phrase is actually redundant given the colon's own equals-sign function.

Trap: Choice C combines a colon with "which was," which is both redundant and grammatically broken, since a colon should be followed directly by the renaming phrase, not by a relative clause.

Core Rules

- **A Pair of Dashes Boxes In a Nonessential Interruption** — Exactly like a matched pair of commas, two dashes can set off nonessential material in the middle of a sentence — but once you open the interruption with a dash, you must close it with a dash, not a comma or a parenthesis.
- **A Single Dash Can Introduce an Emphatic Explanation, Like a Colon** — At the end of an independent clause, one dash can introduce a final word, phrase, or explanation with more emphasis than a colon would give — but the same completeness rule applies: what comes before the dash must be a full sentence.
- **Dashes Are Especially Useful When the Interruption Itself Contains Commas** — If the nonessential phrase already has commas inside it, boxing it in with dashes instead of commas keeps the sentence's structure clear and avoids a pile-up of ambiguous commas.

Common Trap: One dash paired with one comma around the same interruption — the most common dash error on the exam.

The recipe's essential components_____ are combined in a single bowl before the dough is left to rest overnight.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A.** — flour, butter, sugar, and a pinch of salt —
- B.** — flour, butter, sugar, and a pinch of salt,
- C.** , flour, butter, sugar, and a pinch of salt,
- D.** flour, butter, sugar, and a pinch of salt

Correct Answer: A. — flour, butter, sugar, and a pinch of salt —

Explanation

- The nonessential list "flour, butter, sugar, and a pinch of salt" sits in the middle of the sentence and already contains its own internal commas.
- Dashes are especially useful here, since boxing the list in commas instead would create a confusing pile-up of commas.
- As with any mid-sentence interruption, the pair of dashes must match on both sides.

Rule: When a nonessential mid-sentence phrase already contains its own commas, box it in with a matching pair of dashes instead, to keep the sentence's structure clear.

Tip: If the interrupting phrase is itself a comma-filled list, dashes are almost always the cleaner, correct choice over a second layer of commas.

Trap: Choice C uses commas to box in a phrase that already contains commas, creating exactly the kind of confusing comma pile-up dashes are meant to avoid.

Core Rules

- A Period May Only Separate Two Independent Clauses — Everything before a period must be able to stand completely alone as its own grammatically complete sentence — a subject, a finite verb, and a complete thought.
- A Period Can Never Follow a Dependent Clause or Phrase — A clause that opens with because, although, since, which, or that depends on the rest of the sentence to complete its meaning — ending it with a period turns it into a fragment.
- A Direct Question Needs a Question Mark, Not a Period — Regardless of how the rest of the sentence is punctuated internally, a sentence that directly asks something must end in a question mark.

Common Trap: A participial phrase ("...finally reaching a compromise") that sounds complete but has no finite main verb.

Even though the underlying concept seemed simple at first glance_____ the engineering team spent nearly three days resolving unexpected implementation problems.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A.** ,
- B.** .
- C.** ;
- D.** and

Correct Answer: A. ,

Explanation

- "Even though the underlying concept seemed simple at first glance" is an introductory dependent clause, not a complete sentence on its own.
- An introductory dependent clause is separated from the main clause by a single comma — not a period.
- Ending the dependent clause with a period, as Choice B does, would create a sentence fragment.

Rule: A period can never follow a dependent clause — a clause that opens with "even though," "although," or "because" needs a comma, not a period, before the main clause continues.

Tip: Before placing a period, check whether the words right before it could truly stand alone as their own complete sentence. A clause starting with "even though" never can.

Trap: Because the dependent clause here is a full ten words long and feels complete in isolation, a period feels tempting — but length has nothing to do with whether a clause is independent.

Core Rules

- Independent Clauses Can Stand Alone — An independent clause has a subject, a finite verb, and expresses a complete thought with nothing missing — it could be its own sentence, ending in a period, with no changes.
- Dependent Clauses Have a Subject and a Verb but Cannot Stand Alone — A dependent clause looks like a full sentence — it has its own subject and verb — but a subordinating word at the front makes it incomplete on its own; it needs an independent clause to attach to.
- "Which" Clauses Are Nonessential; "That" Clauses Are Essential — A which-clause adds removable, extra information and takes a comma before it; a that-clause identifies exactly which noun is meant and never takes a comma.

Common Trap: A dependent clause punctuated with a period because its idea feels emotionally or logically complete.

The new subway line finally opened after a decade of delays_____ came as a relief to daily commuters across the city.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A.** , which
- B.** , that
- C.** . Which
- D.** which

Correct Answer: A. , which

Explanation

- "Which came as a relief to daily commuters" refers back to the entire preceding idea — the fact that the line finally opened — not to a single specific noun.
- "Which" can introduce a nonessential clause describing a whole preceding idea, and it takes a comma before it.
- "That" cannot be used this way to introduce a nonessential clause commenting on an entire idea.

Rule: "Which" can refer back to an entire preceding clause or idea, not just a single noun — when it does, it is nonessential and takes a comma before it.

Tip: If the clause after the blank comments on the whole situation just described, rather than naming one specific noun, look for a comma plus "which," not "that."

Trap: Choice C turns "Which came as a relief..." into its own sentence, but a clause beginning with "which" can never stand alone as a complete sentence.

Core Rules

- A Run-On Has Zero Punctuation Between Two Independent Clauses — When two complete sentences are jammed together with nothing at all separating them, the result is a run-on — regardless of how naturally it reads aloud.
- A Comma Splice Uses Only a Comma, With No Conjunction — Joining two independent clauses with a lone comma — no FANBOYS conjunction after it — is a comma splice, one of the most heavily tested errors on the exam.
- Four Legal Fixes, and Only Four — Two independent clauses can be joined by a period, a semicolon, a comma plus a FANBOYS conjunction (for, and, nor, but, or, yet, so), or by subordinating one of the clauses so it's no longer independent.

Common Trap: A comma splice that sounds smooth and logically connected, hiding the missing conjunction.

The proposal has strong grassroots support_____ several senior board members remain openly skeptical.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A.** , but
- B.** , however
- C.** ; however
- D.** but

Correct Answer: A. , but

Explanation

- Both clauses are independent, so a comma plus a coordinating conjunction like "but" is a valid, standard fix.
- "However" is a conjunctive adverb, not one of the FANBOYS coordinating conjunctions, so it cannot follow a plain comma between two independent clauses.
- A semicolon before "however" is on the right track, but that construction requires a comma after "however" as well — which Choice C omits.

Rule: "But," "and," "or," and the rest of the FANBOYS conjunctions pair with a comma; "however" and similar conjunctive adverbs pair with a semicolon before them and a comma after.

Tip: Before selecting a comma-plus-word answer, confirm the word is actually one of the seven FANBOYS conjunctions — for, and, nor, but, or, yet, so — not a conjunctive adverb like "however" or "therefore."

Trap: Choice C gets the semicolon right for "however" but drops the comma that must follow it, a detail that's easy to miss.

Core Rules

- **Participial Phrases (-ing / -ed) Are Never Complete Sentences Alone** — A phrase that opens with an -ing or -ed word describes an action but has no finite verb of its own — it must attach to an independent clause.
- **Prepositional Phrases Have No Subject or Verb** — A phrase beginning with despite, because of, from, with, or another preposition can be long and detailed but never contains its own subject-verb pair, so it can never stand alone.
- **That / Which / Who Clauses Depend on the Noun They Describe** — A relative clause beginning with that, which, or who cannot be punctuated as its own sentence — it needs the noun it modifies attached directly to it.

Common Trap: A participial phrase mistaken for a verb because it describes an action.

The company launched a new product line_____ designed specifically for small, budget-conscious businesses.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A.** , one
- B.** . One
- C.** , one,
- D.** one

Think it through, then advance for the full walkthrough.

Correct Answer: A. , one

Explanation

- "One designed specifically for small, budget-conscious businesses" is a nonessential phrase describing "product line," built around the participle "designed," not a finite verb.
- A comma correctly attaches this appositive-style phrase to the main clause.
- Choice B punctuates it as its own sentence, but "One designed specifically for..." has no finite main verb and cannot stand alone.

Rule: A phrase that renames or describes a noun using a participle (here, "designed") stays attached to that noun with a comma — it has no finite verb and cannot be punctuated as its own sentence.

Tip: If a phrase after a comma starts with a pronoun like "one" followed by a past participle, check whether a true finite verb exists anywhere in it before treating it as a complete sentence.

Trap: "One designed specifically for small, budget-conscious businesses" contains enough specific, meaningful detail that it's easy to mistake for a complete sentence.

Core Rules

- Cause / Effect Connectors Signal a Direct Result — Words like so, therefore, thus, consequently, and as a result mean the second idea happened because of the first — there must be a genuine causal link, not just two facts placed near each other.
- Contrast Connectors Signal the Second Idea Works Against the First — But, however, yet, although, and nevertheless all signal that the second idea opposes, limits, or surprises the first — the two ideas move in different directions.
- Addition Connectors Stack Two Related, Same-Direction Facts — And, moreover, furthermore, and in addition simply add a second fact that points the same direction as the first, without any cause, contrast, or concession implied.

Common Trap: A connector that sounds sophisticated but signals the wrong relationship entirely (for example, "consequently" where the ideas actually contrast).

The new manufacturing process reduced material waste by nearly a third_____ it also cut average production time almost in half.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A. , and

B. , but

C. , so

D. , yet

Correct Answer: A. , and

Explanation

- Both facts — reduced waste and cut production time — are separate benefits of the same process, pointing in the same direction.
- "And" correctly signals that the second fact simply adds to the first, without contrast or causation.
- "So" would incorrectly suggest that reducing waste directly caused the drop in production time, rather than the two being independent benefits.

Rule: When two facts are simply stacked together as separate, same-direction points, use an addition connector (and, moreover, in addition) rather than a cause-and-effect or contrast word.

Tip: Ask whether the second fact is caused by the first, opposes it, or is simply an additional, related point. Only the third case calls for a plain addition connector.

Trap: "So" is tempting because both improvements plausibly came from the same new process, but that shared origin doesn't mean one improvement directly caused the other.

Core Rules

- Adjectives Modify Nouns and Pronouns; Adverbs Modify Everything Else — An adjective describes a noun or pronoun directly; an adverb describes a verb, an adjective, or another adverb — usually, though not always, ending in -ly.
- After a Linking Verb, Use an Adjective; After an Action Verb, Use an Adverb — Verbs like is, seems, appears, becomes, and feels link the subject to a description of the subject itself, so they take an adjective — not an adverb describing how the verb "happens."
- Certain Words Take One Fixed, Memorized Preposition — Many adjectives and verbs pair with exactly one correct preposition by convention, not by logic — these idiomatic pairings must simply be known.

Common Trap: An adjective placed after a linking verb where an adverb is wrongly expected, or vice versa.

The results of the new clinical trial are entirely consistent_____ findings published in three earlier studies.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A.** with
- B.** to
- C.** of
- D.** for

Think it through, then advance for the full walkthrough.

Correct Answer: A. with

Explanation

- "Consistent" is idiomatically paired with the preposition "with," not any other preposition.
- This pairing is fixed by convention, not by logic, and must simply be known.
- "Consistent to," "consistent of," and "consistent for" are all nonstandard combinations.

Rule: Certain adjectives pair with exactly one correct, memorized preposition — "consistent with" is one of the most frequently tested examples.

Tip: When a sentence tests a word you recognize as needing a specific preposition, trust the memorized pairing over what merely sounds acceptable in the moment.

Trap: "Consistent to" can sound plausible if you're reasoning from a similar phrase like "true to," but the fixed idiom is specifically "consistent with."

Core Rules

- Future Perfect Signals a Deadline: "By [a Time]" — When a sentence names a future point in time by which something will be finished, the verb takes the future perfect form: will have + past participle.
- Hypothetical "If" Clauses Never Contain "Would" — In a contrary-to-fact if-clause, use the simple past (for a real hypothetical) or the past perfect (for a hypothetical about the past); "would" belongs only in the result clause that follows, never in the if-clause itself.
- Contrary-to-Fact "To Be" Uses "Were," Not "Was" — In a hypothetical if-clause describing something not actually true, the verb "to be" takes the subjunctive form "were" for every subject, including I, he, she, and it.

Common Trap: "Would" slipped into the if-clause of a hypothetical instead of staying in the result clause.

If the museum's east wing_____ open on Mondays, attendance would likely climb by double digits.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A.** were
- B.** was
- C.** is
- D.** will be

Correct Answer: A. were

Explanation

- The result clause, "attendance would likely climb," signals a contrary-to-fact hypothetical — the east wing is not, in reality, open on Mondays.
- In a contrary-to-fact if-clause, the verb "to be" takes the subjunctive form "were," regardless of the subject.
- "Was," the ordinary past tense form, is nonstandard in this specifically hypothetical construction.

Rule: In a contrary-to-fact if-clause, "to be" takes the subjunctive form "were" for every subject — never "was," even with a singular subject like "the east wing."

Tip: When the result clause uses "would" to describe something that isn't actually true, check the if-clause specifically for "were" rather than "was."

Trap: Because "the east wing" is singular, "was" can feel like the naturally "matching" verb form — but the hypothetical mood overrides ordinary subject-verb agreement here.

Core Rules

- Cross Out Everything Between the Subject and the Verb — The SAT hides the real subject behind long prepositional phrases and modifying clauses — physically crossing them out (or covering them) reveals the true subject the verb must agree with.
- Phrases Like "Along With" Never Change the Subject's Number — Along with, as well as, together with, and in addition to introduce extra information but do not make a subject plural — the verb still agrees with the original subject alone.
- Collective Nouns and Indefinite Pronouns Are Singular — Words like team, committee, jury, and company name a single unit and take a singular verb; indefinite pronouns like each, every, everyone, and neither are always singular too, regardless of how many individuals they describe.

Common Trap: A verb agreeing with the nearest noun in a long modifying phrase instead of the true subject.

Economics_____ widely regarded as one of the most rigorous social sciences taught at the university.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A.** is
- B.** are
- C.** have been
- D.** were

Correct Answer: A. is

Explanation

- "Economics" ends in -s but names a single field of study, not multiple items.
- Like mathematics, physics, and athletics, this kind of noun is always grammatically singular, regardless of its plural-looking spelling.
- A plural verb here would incorrectly treat the field of study as if it were a collection of multiple things.

Rule: Some nouns end in -s but name a single subject, field, or activity — economics, mathematics, physics, athletics — and are always singular, taking a singular verb.

Tip: When a noun's -s ending tempts a plural verb, check whether the word actually names one unified field or activity rather than a countable group of separate items.

Trap: The -s at the end of "economics" looks exactly like a regular plural ending, making a plural verb feel automatic — but this category of noun doesn't follow that pattern.

Core Rules

- A Pronoun's Antecedent Must Be an Actual Noun, Not a Possessive — A pronoun can only refer back to a noun functioning as a noun — a possessive form like "the director's" or "Maria's" is functioning as an adjective, and a pronoun cannot legally point back to it.
- A Pronoun With More Than One Possible Antecedent Is Ambiguous — If a pronoun could logically point to two or more different nouns in the sentence, it is treated as an error even when the intended meaning seems clear from context — the sentence must be rewritten to name the specific noun.
- Subject Form Performs the Action; Object Form Receives It — Who, they, and he perform the action of the verb; whom, them, and him receive it. Substituting a simple pronoun like he/him into the clause reveals which case is correct.

Common Trap: A pronoun pointing to a possessive noun instead of an actual stand-alone noun.

In the director's acceptance speech,_____ thanked the entire crew for their dedication.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A.** the director
- B.** she
- C.** her
- D.** it

Correct Answer: A. the director

Explanation

- "The director's" is a possessive form, functioning as an adjective describing "speech" — it is not a stand-alone noun.
- A pronoun like "she" cannot legally refer back to a possessive form; it needs an actual noun as its antecedent.
- Repeating the actual noun, "the director," is the only option here that avoids this illegal pronoun reference.

Rule: A pronoun's antecedent must be an actual noun functioning as a noun — never a possessive form like "the director's," which functions only as an adjective.

Tip: When a sentence opens with a possessive noun ("the director's," "Maria's"), check whether a later pronoun tries to refer back to it — if so, that reference is illegal, no matter how clear the intended meaning seems.

Trap: "She" feels completely natural and unambiguous to a reader, since it's obvious in context who gave the speech — but the sentence's only available antecedent, "director's," is grammatically possessive, not a plain noun.

Core Rules

- Countable Nouns Take "Fewer"; Non-Count Nouns Take "Less" — If you could count the noun one by one (one error, two errors, three errors), use fewer; if the noun is a mass or an abstract quantity that isn't counted in individual units (water, information, time), use less.
- Singular Possession Always Adds 's, Even After a Final -s — To show that a singular noun owns something, add 's — this rule holds even when the noun already ends in -s.
- Regular Plural Possession Adds Only an Apostrophe After the -s — When a plural noun already ends in -s, its possessive form adds just an apostrophe — no second s.

Common Trap: "Less" used with a plainly countable noun (people, errors, dollars) instead of "fewer."

After_____ experience conducting fieldwork in three different climate zones, she was promoted to senior researcher and given her own team.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A.** five years'
- B.** five year's
- C.** five years
- D.** five year

Correct Answer: A. five years'

Explanation

- This is a time-expression possessive, similar to "a day's work" or "ten dollars' worth."
- Since the amount is plural ("five years"), the possessive apostrophe goes after the final -s.
- The phrase describes experience that belongs to, or spans, five years, requiring the possessive form.

Rule: Time and amount expressions (a day's work, three years' experience, ten dollars' worth) take a possessive apostrophe just as if the time period were an owner.

Tip: Time and amount expressions like "a day's work," "three years' experience," and "ten dollars' worth" follow standard possessive rules — treat the time period as an "owner."

Trap: Choice C, without any apostrophe, might seem sufficient since "years" already shows the amount of time — but the idiomatic possessive construction still requires the apostrophe.

Core Rules

- Two Items Take the Comparative; Three or More Take the Superlative — Comparing exactly two things requires the comparative form (-er or "more"); comparing three or more requires the superlative (-est or "most").
- Never Double a Comparative or Superlative Form — A word takes either the -er/-est ending or "more"/"most" before it — never both at once.
- Absolute Adjectives Cannot Be Intensified — Words like unique, perfect, complete, and impossible already describe an all-or-nothing quality — they logically cannot be "very" or "more" of that quality.

Common Trap: A superlative used to compare only two things, or a comparative used to compare three or more.

Although several earlier studies had explored similar phenomena in laboratory settings, the results of this particular field experiment were widely regarded as remarkably_____, since no other study had produced anything comparable.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A.** very unique
- B.** completely unique
- C.** particularly unique
- D.** unique

Correct Answer: D. unique

Explanation

- "Unique" means one-of-a-kind and is already an absolute quality.
- Absolute adjectives like "unique," "perfect," and "impossible" cannot logically be intensified.
- Removing the intensifier entirely produces the grammatically correct sentence.

Rule: Absolute adjectives (unique, perfect, complete, impossible) describe an all-or-nothing quality and cannot logically be intensified by words like "very" or "completely."

Tip: Watch for absolute adjectives (unique, perfect, complete, impossible) paired with intensifiers like "very" or "completely" — the intensifier is always redundant and should be removed.

Trap: Intensifiers like "very" and "completely" feel like they add emphasis in everyday speech, which makes "very unique" sound natural despite being logically redundant.

Core Rules

- **Dangling Modifier: The Word Being Described Is Missing Entirely** — An opening participial phrase describes whoever performs its action — if that person or thing never actually appears as the subject of the main clause, the modifier dangles with nothing to attach to.
- **Misplaced Modifier: The Right Word Exists but Sits Too Far Away** — When a modifying phrase is placed too far from the word it's meant to describe, other nouns in between create confusion about what's actually being modified.
- **Squinting Modifier: The Phrase Could Attach to Either Side** — A modifier placed between two clauses or phrases creates real ambiguity when it could logically describe what comes before it or what comes after it.

Common Trap: An opening phrase followed by an inanimate object or abstract noun that logically cannot perform the described action.

The professor_____ who had won the Nobel Prize decades earlier for her work on cellular repair mechanisms_____ still lectures every Tuesday morning to a packed auditorium.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A. , ... ,

B. — ... —

C. (no punctuation) ... (no punctuation)

D. ; ... ;

Correct Answer: A. , ... ,

Explanation

- "Who had won the Nobel Prize decades earlier for her work on cellular repair mechanisms" is a nonessential clause interrupting the subject and verb.
- A nonessential clause needs matching punctuation marks on both sides.
- Commas are the standard, correct choice for this nonessential interruption in a plainly stated sentence.

Rule: A nonessential interrupting clause must be boxed in by a matching pair of punctuation marks — commas, dashes, or occasionally parentheses — never a single mark on only one side.

Tip: Dashes and commas can both correctly box in a nonessential interruption, but pick the mark that matches the sentence's tone — plain, factual sentences typically use commas rather than the more dramatic dash.

Trap: Dashes (Choice B) are also grammatically valid for boxing in nonessential information, which can make it tempting when a sentence contains other punctuation nearby — but consistency with the sentence's neutral tone favors commas here.

Core Rules

- Every Item in a List Must Match the First Item's Grammatical Form — Once the first item in a series establishes a pattern — a verb form, a noun, a gerund, an infinitive — every remaining item must follow that identical pattern.
- Correlative Pairs Require Matching Structure on Both Sides — Not only...but also, either...or, neither...nor, and both...and are fixed two-part phrases — whatever grammatical structure follows the first half must be mirrored exactly after the second half.
- FANBOYS Join Equal, Independent Elements; Subordinators Create Dependent Clauses — Coordinating conjunctions (for, and, nor, but, or, yet, so) join two grammatically equal elements, often two independent clauses; subordinating conjunctions (because, although, since, while) instead turn one clause into a dependent one that relies on the other.

Common Trap: One item in an otherwise-parallel list quietly switching form (a gerund among infinitives, a noun among verb phrases).

According to the latest census figures released this year, the population of metropolitan Tokyo is now considerably larger than_____ metropolitan London.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A.** that of
- B.** those of
- C.** the city of
- D.** (no word needed)

Correct Answer: A. that of

Explanation

- The sentence compares "the population of metropolitan Tokyo" to a population, not to a city itself.
- "That of" correctly stands in for "the population of," keeping the comparison apples-to-apples.
- "Those" (Choice B) would be needed only if the compared item were plural, which "population" (singular) is not.

Rule: When comparing possessive or "of" phrases, use "that of" (singular) or "those of" (plural) to stand in for the first noun, keeping the comparison logically consistent.

Tip: When comparing possessive or "of" phrases, use "that of" (singular) or "those of" (plural) to stand in for the first noun, keeping the comparison logically consistent.

Trap: Leaving out any comparison word (Choice D) creates an illogical comparison between "the population of metropolitan Tokyo" and simply "metropolitan London" — a population and a city are not the same kind of thing.